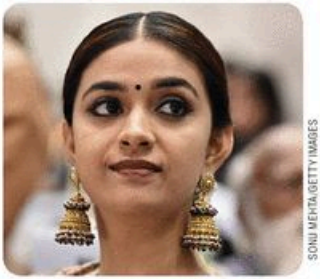
"I never wanted to get into the film industry or become an actor. I used to lock myself in my room when stars came home. So all this just happened"

DHANUSH
to Film Companion,
March 2021

that have come mainly with Selvaraghavan in his initial days, and now with strikingly original filmmakers like Vetrimaaran and Mari Selvaraj. He won his first National Award in 2010 for the Vetrimaaran film Aadukaalam and hasn't looked back since. He is also the rare multi-hyphenated star actor in the mould of Kamal Haasan, a producer with a film that was India's entry for Best International Feature in 2016—*Visaaranai*—and also on many occasions as a lyricist (*Ilamai Thirumbudhe*)/ singer (*Why this Kolaveri Di*)/ director (Pa. *Paandi*) who is just about to break loose. ■

–Aditya Shrikrishna

FLASHBACKS Dhanush's directorial debut, *Pa. Paandi*, starred Rajkiran in the lead. Rajkiran also acted in Dhanush's father Kasthuri Raja's debut film *En Rasavin Manasile* in 1991. The poster of that film can be seen in Vetrimaaran's *Vada Chennai*, a film set in the 1980-'90s



SONU MEHTA/GETTY IMAGES

KEERTHY SURESH, 29

Actor

SOUTHERN SIREN

Daughter of Malayalam film producer G. Suresh Kumar and Tamil actress Menaka, cinema ran in Keerthy's blood. She appeared as a child actor in some of her father's productions, but then went on to study fashion design at the Pearl Academy in Chennai. Soon, however, she realised cinema was her true calling, and began acting in Malayalam, Tamil and Telugu cinema.

While her initial years as an actor were eclipsed by the heroes of the films (*Rajini Murugan*, *Remo*, *Sarkar*, *Bairavaa*), it was with the 2018 film *Mahanati* (The Great Actress) that she came into her own. A biopic of one of the greatest actors of Indian cinema—Savitri—casting Keerthy in the iconic role invited a lot of scepticism. Soon, however, Keerthy turned all her critics into believers, going on to win a national award for her performance. *Mahanati* paved the way for more titular and well-defined roles in *Penguin*, *Miss India* and *Annaatthe*. The Great Actress had, indeed, arrived. ■

"I want to keep redefining myself. I can't have just one iconic character and think that's just about it"

– Aditya Shrikrishna

GREATEST COMMON FACTOR
Keerthy's mum Menaka was paired opposite Rajinikanth in *Netrikann* (1981). Keerthy now plays Rajini's sister in *Annaatthe* (2021).